

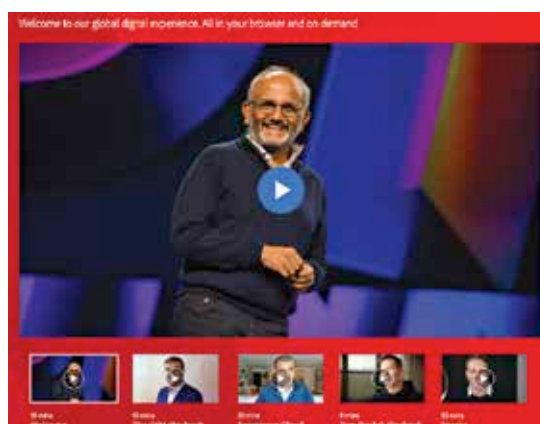
Xeno NFT Hub said, “We strongly believe that blockchain and its application to NFT technology will change the landscape of ownership and digital rights in profound ways.”

04 HYBRID EVENTS

The sudden disruptions in 2020 forced a number of events to unexpectedly go entirely online, and the whole world figured out effective ways of doing this. Disney+ Hotstar involved the users in the streaming experience for IPL matches, called Watch’N Play, by asking them to post short video “duets” of themselves replicating shots from batsmen. Some of the best virtual events such as DC FanDome or the Adobe Summit surprisingly and effectively used video on demand components instead of going for a live experience. Video conferencing platforms grew by leaps and bounds, and were continuously updating their products with features aimed at working professionals, teachers and health-care workers. Throughout all this though, those organising the events did not have the tools needed to do so. Going forward, there will be a need for more sophisticated virtual event technologies, including cloud-based and provided as SaaS, because everyone found out one thing - that virtual events are awesome even without a Holodeck. The participation is from a larger number of more focused fans from all around the world, you get to have more fruitful interactions, and be done with minimal time waste. Going forward, we can expect a hybridisation of events, where all meatspace events will have virtual modules.

Research by Splash, an event management technology company shows that 79 per cent of companies intend to have a virtual component even after the resumption of in-person events. The research also indicates

that an increasing number of events will be planned, organised and hosted by non-marketers. Eric Holmen, Chief Revenue Officer of Splash says, “Our latest report highlights the resilience of event professionals and the immense structural changes in the events landscape.” The virtual event economy was just a seed in the ground, but now it has fertiliser and water, what remains to be seen is how it grows. QuHarrison Terry, Future Thinker at Trends Exchange says, “Entertainment-related events are making a natural transition to virtual. Instagram Live events like Quarantine Radio and Verzuz Battles



The on demand experience offered during the Adobe Summit event

are bringing in concurrent viewerships of upwards of 500,000 people. They’re pushing the upper limits of virtual events. How this success translates to the professional setting is still very much to be determined.”

05 SHORT VIDEO APPS

The demand for short video apps to replace TikTok after the ban was so intense, that the downloads of some apps such as Chingari almost rivaled that of Ludo King for a couple of weeks. The Indian players that were consistently around for a long time, and integrating with brands all along such as Roposo got a shot in the arm. Rizzle saw a spike in downloads too, and innovated with the production of one of the first “originals” for short video platforms. Vidya Narayanan, Co-founder of Rizzle App, said,

“Indian content creators are highly talented. After the ban of TikTok and other Chinese apps, we see an enormous adoption of Indian apps by such innovative talent in our country. Our PM’s Vocal for Local is our inspiration to take the homegrown app Rizzle to not just a local audience but to a global audience too. We acknowledge the limited number of platforms available for those who have a flair for creating original short content and to this end, we have launched “RSeries Originals”

Marketing and PR companies are still to gain confidence in any new platform, at the same scale as TikTok in India. However, at the present time, Instagram Reels looks like the option with the most promise. Google got into the game too, with YouTube Shorts, initially meant to be a new way for creators to engage with their audiences, by producing short videos in between the regular uploads on the channel. The new feature has been rolled out to a select few channels in India, and end-users started seeing the first short video content in the last days of December 2020. We can expect more activity in the short video space in the coming year ahead. In fact, in 2020 the demand was so much that unlikely players got into the action too, such as the video streaming service Zee5 that launched HiPi, and the music streaming platform Gaana that launched its own integrated short video platform, HotShots. The TikTok ban has left a hole that is waiting to be filled.

06 DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION

This might sound like an old buzzword from 10 or even 20 years ago, but the truth is that the process of integrating technologies into businesses is usually a slow process. Previously, we’d seen large enterprises use the term abundantly and now we’re see a democratisation of the same across all sectors. The pandemic changed all that up and we started seeing accelerated technology adapta-